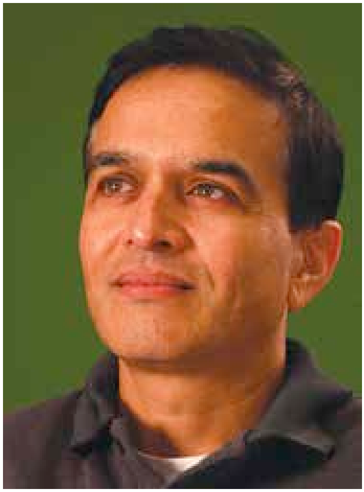
an expert in a certain technology, for instance, L2 design, and be a mentor or Senior Fellow.

As for the salaries in this industry, a fresher starts off at around 5 lakhs per annum while a Lead Engineer generally gets 8-12 lakhs. In a few years, one can progress to Project Lead where 12-20 lakhs is the norm and the sky is the limit, depending on the brand.



"Seeing technologies you've worked on, being put into day to day use is quite an exhilarating experience!"

— Rohit Vidwans
Former Director of Digital Enterprise Group, Intel India

Summing it up

For a successful career in any field, you need to have a special interest in the subject and a dream to make a difference. Chip design is an extremely fulfilling career option for the technically and technologically inclined. Conscious choices have to be made along the way which may be less rewarding in the short run, such as going in for a focused Masters with a good project. The money and lucrative job offers will follow once you've developed the required skill sets and gained the experience.

As for the areas to look out for, the general consensus is that chips designed for consumer electronics is a growth area. Designing for wireless devices and multi-core processor design is bound to go up too, while integration of MEMS (Micro-Electro-Mechanical Systems) is a growth area that has great applications in the healthcare and medical arena. Entertainment and graphics technologies coupled with designing chips that give you higher performance at lower power consumption should be the focus for young entrants. "The dawn of energy age has increased demand on semiconductors to do more with less energy (performance per unit of energy). Another trend is towards always-on mobile connected devices. This is giving a push to cloud computing where most of the